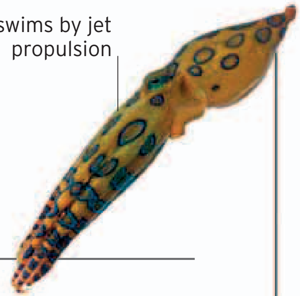
Greater blue-ringed octopus

Hapalochlaena lunulata



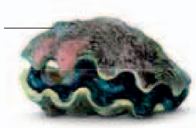
Although small enough to fit in a teacup, this species poses the greatest danger to humans of any octopus. It rests by day in rocky crevices close to the shore, piling up a wall of stones for extra privacy. If disturbed, the octopus can give a deadly bite. Fatalities are rare, but its saliva contains tetrodotoxin, a poison 10,000 times more toxic than cyanide. It hunts on the seabed, catching prey with its beak or paralyzing it by releasing poison into the water.

- 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
- Not known
- Fish, crabs, shrimp
- Indo-Pacific, S. Australia coasts

▷ **BLUE ALERT**
If the octopus is alarmed, its rings turn electric blue, warning that a deadly bite will follow.

Giant clam

Tridacna gigas



The giant clam is the largest living mollusk. Its immense shell is opened and closed by a powerful muscle, and animals sometimes get trapped, although the giant clam is not carnivorous. It feeds by filtering suspended food items from seawater. Adult giant clams also get nutrients from algae that live inside their fleshy tissues. These single-celled plants need light to photosynthesize, which restricts the clams to shallow, sunlit areas.

△ **SPAWNING**
Giant clams start life as males and later become hermaphrodites. However, they only release either eggs or sperm during a spawning session to avoid self-fertilization.

- 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- Vulnerable
- Algae, plankton
- Indo-Pacific, Pacific Ocean

Portuguese man o' war

Physalia physalis

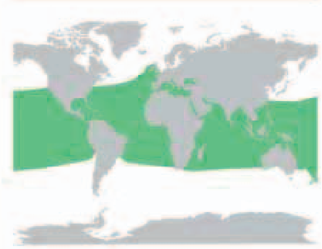
This relative of jellyfish floats on the surface of the ocean, snaring fish in its stinging tentacles that trail for 33 ft (10 m) or more below the surface. It is named after a passing resemblance between its gas-filled float and the distinctive curved sails of an 18th-century fighting ship. The Portuguese man o' war is unable to power its own movements, and the float, or pneumatophore, is also a sail of sorts, intended to catch the wind, which takes the organism wherever it may.

Colonial creature

A man o' war looks like a single animal but is actually a colony of several individual polyps, all of which connect beneath the float. There are three polyp types, each adapted for a particular job. The dactylozooids develop the long blue-green tentacles. These are lined with stinging cells, which are primed to fire barbed venomous darts into anything that touches them. The tentacles are used in defense and can inflict thousands of painful stings on anyone who tangles with them. The stingers also gather food, which is slowly hoisted up the tentacle to the gastrozooids, the feeding polyps. These engulf prey of all sizes and secrete enzymes to digest them.

The third polyp type—the reproductive gonozooid—has male and female parts, which produce new larval individuals that bud off from the main body to start life on their own.

- 33–165 ft (10–50 m)
- Not known
- Small fish, plankton



Tropical and temperate oceans

▷ **DRIFTING DANGER**
The float is mostly air, topped up with carbon monoxide. If attacked at the surface, the gas is released so the man o' war can sink safely underwater.